Shapechangers in Winter

By Margaret Atwood

INTRODUCTION

My grandparents have a marriage I greatly admire. While I'm sure that grandma and grandpa have their share of differences, they seem to really enjoy being with each other. They've been married for 40 years, and despite the graying hair, wrinkling skin and widening waists, their affection appears to have deepened. In fact, they even seem to embrace the aging process! They have always seemed so in sync.

Everyone talks about people growing and changing over time. And I'm sure the same is true of a marriage. Circumstances change. New situations arise. Marriages need to adjust.

How could the terms of a marriage contracted at 25 possibly be the same at 50 or 60 or 70? It makes sense that marriages need to be flexible. But facing the need to change can be frightening and threatening. Shapechanging in Winter by Margaret Atwood.

1.

Through the slit of our open window, the wind

comes in and flows around us, nothingness

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in motion, like time. The power of what is not there.

The snow empties itself down, a shadow turning

to indigo, obliterating

everything out there, roofs, cars, garbage cans,

dead flowerstalks, dog turds, it doesn't matter.

You could read this as indifference

on the part of the universe, or else a relentless

forgiveness: all of our

scratches and blots and mortal

wounds and patched-up jobs

wiped clean in the snow's huge erasure.

I feel it as a pressure,

an added layer:

above the white waterfall of snow

thundering down; then attic, moth-balled

sweaters, nomadic tents,

the dried words of old letters;

then stairs, then children, cats and radiators, peeling

paint,

us in our bed, the afterglow

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of a smoky fire, our one candle flickering;
below us, the kitchen in the dark, the wink
of pots on shelves; then books and tools, then cellar
and furnace, graying dolls, a bicycle,
the whole precarious geology of house
crisscrossed with hidden mousetrails,
and under that a buried river
that seeps up through the cement
floor every spring,
and the tree roots snouting their slow way
into the drains;
under that, the bones
of our ancestors, or if not theirs, someone's,
mixed with a biomass of nematodes;
under that, bedrock, then molten
stone and the earth's fiery core;
and sideways, out into the city, street
and corner store and mall
and underpass, then barns and ruined woodlands,
continent
and island, oceans, mists

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of story drifting
on the tide like seaweed, animal
species crushed and blinking out,
and births and illnesses, hatred and love infra-
red, compassion fleshtone, prayer ultra-
violet; then rumours, alternate waves
of sad peace and sad war,
and then the air, and then the scintillating ions,
and then the stars. That's where
we are.

2.

Some centuries ago, when we lived at the edge
of the forest, on nights like this
you would have put on your pelt of a bear
and shambled off to prowl and hulk
among the trees, and be a silhouette of human
fears against the snowbank.
I would have chosen fox;
I liked the jokes,
the doubling back on my tracks,

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and, let's face it, the theft.
Back then, I had many forms:
the sliding in and out
of my own slippery eelskin,
and yours as well; we were each other's
iridescent glove, the deft body
all sleight-of-hand and illusion.
Once we were lithe as pythons, quick
and silvery as herring, and we still are, momentarily,
except our knees hurt.
Right now we're content to huddle
under the shed feathers of duck and goose
as the wind pours like a river
we swim in by keeping still,
like trout in a current.
Every cell
in our bodies has renewed itself
so many times since then, there's
not much left, my love,
of the originals. We're footprints
becoming limestone, or think of it

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as coal becoming diamond. Less
flexible, but more condensed;
and no more scales or aliases,
at least on the outside. Though we've accumulated,
despite ourselves, other disguises:
you as a rumpled elephant—
hide suitcase with white fur,
me as a bramble bush. Well, the hair
was always difficult. Then there's
the eye problems: too close, too far, you're a blur.
I used to say I'd know you anywhere,
but it's getting harder.

3.

This is the solstice, the still point
of the sun, its cusp and midnight,
the year's threshold
and unlocking, where the past
lets go of and becomes the future;
the place of caught breath, the door
of a vanished house left ajar.

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Taking hands like children
lost in a six-dimensional
forest, we step across.
The walls of the house fold themselves down,
and the house turns
itself inside out, as a tulip does
in its last full-blown moment, and our candle
flares up and goes out, and the only common
sense that remains to us is touch,

as it will be, later, some other
century, when we will seem to each other
even less what we were.
But that trick is just to hold on
through all appearances; and so we do,
and yes, I know it's you;
and that is what we will come to, sooner
or later, when it's even darker
than It is now, when the snow is colder,
when it's darkest and coldest

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and candles are no longer any use to us
and the visibility is zero: *Yes.*
It's still you. It's still you.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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